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Charles' commissioners, delegation discuss legislative proposals

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Charles County commissioners and state delegation members discuss 23 legislative proposals during the county commissioners' meeting on Sept. 9 in advance of the upcoming General Assembly.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News



The Charles County commissioners and state delegation convened Tuesday evening to discuss legislative proposals that could be considered during the upcoming General Assembly session.

A total of 23 items were on the docket, including a request to have a recreation amenity fee against each real property tax bill in the county due to the increased population looking for more recreational amenities, Deborah Hall, deputy county administrator for Charles County, said.

“We have many projects out there that we’re interested in funding,” Hall said. “They’re in competition with ... a lot of other items.”

The fee, which could be \$60 a year, will be used for recreation capital improvement projects or recreation general fund expenditures, Kelli Beavers, director of the Department of Recreation, Parks and Tourism, said. Projects include a sports and wellness center and a sports park for competitions.

While the county has \$50 million for the sports and wellness center, the project is expected to be a \$90 million project, Hall said.

“This is something our citizens are asking for,” Commissioner President Reuben B. Collins II (D) said. “We’re really exploring every avenue to find additional resources for the parks and recreation.”

Projects, whether a pool, school or other facilities, are very expensive, Hall said. The fee is expected to generate \$40 million and cover the debt service for the sports and wellness center.

“We would be very, very careful and survey our residents in exactly how much they could stand,” Hall said. “It’s incredibly difficult for young people [and] elderly people to absorb these fees, yet ... the young and elderly people are who would be using these resources.”

Another request was to add language to certain crimes against public health and safety that require someone to provide identification if an officer has probable cause to believe the person has committed a civil offense in Charles County.

Maryland criminal law requires a person to show identification when an officer issues a citation relating to certain alcohol crimes, Misty Good, deputy general counsel for Charles County Sheriff's Office, said. But there is no requirement to produce identification when an officer issues civil citations for most public health and safety crimes including related to alcohol, cannabis, tobacco and gambling.

"When we have people that are excessively drinking or doing cannabis, or doing both together ... we sit and wait for them to urinate in public or litter where it is a criminal offense," sheriff's office Sgt. Chrissy Gilroy said. "I would like to stop the behavior at the civil offense."

The identification does not need to be a physical identification, Gilroy said. It could be telling the officer the person's name and birthday or calling a parent.

The smell of cannabis lingers, Del. Kevin Harris (D-Charles, Prince George's), said. If someone who was smoking cannabis left the scene and someone else arrives, an officer might assume the person who just showed up was the person smoking.

"You can see how that altercation can get more escalated in a way that it should not be," Harris said.

Commissioner Gilbert "BJ" Bowling (D) suggested looking at county codes to "give us some perspective on how other jurisdictions handle it."

The Charles County commissioners will hold a work session on Sept. 23 to select which proposals to move forward.

